To drive home the point about Tata sticking to its principles, he stated, ‘By far, the softer option for Tata Tea all these years would have been to pay cash. That would have made us no different from others. But, if I might say so, that appears to be the approved way of operating.’

Pushed to a Corner

As the chief minister became more antagonistic towards the Tata Group, the government machinery expectedly toed his line. The accusations that Tata Tea was in cahoots with the militants became more malevolent. The Tatas faced the barrage of charges virtually alone as no one was willing to testify on behalf of the group at the time.

The situation was getting worse. Ratan feared that some key functionaries of Tata Tea would be arrested. To stave off such a possibility, it was reported that Wadia’s help was taken again.

Wadia, along with Jethmalani’s son Mahesh, BJP senior member and attorney Arun Jaitley and Delhi-based solicitor Raian Karanjawala secured anticipatory bail for Krishna Kumar, Kidwai and K. Sridhar, consultant with the group, from the Bombay High Court. But it was a short-lived relief as the order had been passed ex-parte. The Assam government filed a special leave petition in the Supreme Court, which transferred the case to the Gauhati High Court. The high court rejected the bail applications and refused to even grant two days’ time for the officials of Tata Tea to move the apex court.

Meanwhile, once the ULFA leaders came to know that the Tata Group had kept the home ministry and the IB informed of its meetings with them, they became antagonistic towards Tata Tea as well. On 14 October 1997, Baruah wrote to the leading newspapers in the country, requesting them to publish his organization’s press release on what it felt was Tata Tea’s ‘conspiracy against the ULFA’.

In a clear reference to Ratan, the press release said, ‘It is because of this double-standard at their highest level that Tata Tea executives in Assam are being victimized and manipulated to protect their higher-ups.’ It concluded, ‘Tata Tea will have to face the consequences in Assam for the double-standard in their dealings with the ULFA.’ This was a personal threat to Ratan and for over a year, he was compelled to go everywhere with a huge posse of policemen, until he decided that he had had enough of security.